

The Media Story

What the product promises, and who it imagines, compared with your real user. Spend 15 minutes with real ads, the app store page or official notices first.

Step 1 · Who does the product think it's for? Describe the person the ads show. Then describe the person who really uses it. The **gap between the two** is what this tool is looking for.

THE PERSON IN THE ADS

Who: [a smiling student]

Has: [own laptop, bright desk]

Doing it: [in one sitting, relaxed]

YOUR REAL USER

Who: [Meera, 19, first-gen]

Has: [a phone at 12%, hostel Wi-Fi]

Doing it: [over 3 days, worried]

THE MISMATCH

The ads assume [a laptop, a scanner and an hour], but my user has [a phone, a café and three days]

A · What it claims

Its main promise, in its own words

["one place for all scholarships"]

A word the ads keep using that the product doesn't live up to

["seamless"]

If a user described it to a friend, they'd say...

["upload karo, reject ho jao, phir se karo"]

B · The story it sells

Where the ads' story starts

[log-in]

Where it ends

["Submitted"]

What it skips

[getting documents, the café, the waiting]

C · What the designers set out to do

The problem they set out to solve, in their own words (launch page, tender, About)

["let students apply for every scholarship on one platform"]

The user they imagined

[own laptop, scanner, broadband]

What they designed against, and what it costs users

[fraud; heavy document checks for everyone]

D · How users experience it

First time (signing up)

[asked for an ID she didn't have with her]

Using it (the main task)

[upload rejected twice, no reason given]

Afterwards (waiting, coming back)

[status says "pending" for weeks]

yellow notes · what you found teal notes · what you think

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

The Gossip Venn

The three circles are three **sources of information** about the product. Collect real quotes from each, then look at where they agree and where they clash.

HOW TO FILL IT

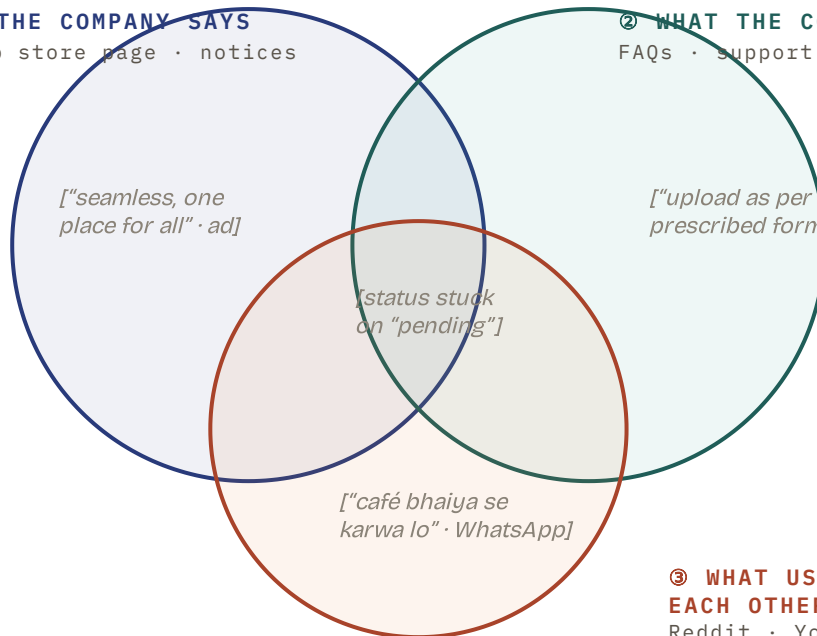
Write each quote on a yellow note, with where you found it. Stick it in the circle it came from. If two sources say the same thing, put it in the overlap. Never invent a quote.

① WHAT THE COMPANY SAYS

ads · app store page · notices

② WHAT THE COMPANY REPLIES

FAQs · support · replies to reviews



③ WHAT USERS TELL EACH OTHER

Reddit · YouTube · WhatsApp

THE HARDEST CONTRADICTION · teal notes · what you think

Circle ① says "[track your status anytime]", but circle ③ says "[nobody can tell you where your application is]".

Why hasn't it been fixed? Who gains from it staying this way?

[the helpdesk only answers FAQs; agents earn from the confusion]

WHERE TO FIND ③

Reddit

Quora

YouTube comments

WhatsApp forwards

Facebook groups

Your interviews

ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

The timeline

What the product replaced, who lost or gained a role, and which way influence flows. Best done by talking to someone who did it before it went digital.

Then	Recently	Now
<i>[paper form; principal signs; father takes it to the district office; a clerk checks it]</i>	<i>[apply online, then hand a printout to the college]</i>	<i>[fully online; OTP to a registered phone; college verifies]</i>
PEOPLE → PRODUCT A workaround users invented that the product now depends on <i>[the café "setting" for 200KB PDFs]</i>	PRODUCT → PEOPLE A habit or skill the product forced on everyone <i>[owning a PDF, an OTP number and an email]</i>	

Who lost a role?
[the clerk who could explain and make exceptions]

Who gained one?
[cybercafé owners, form-filling agents]

What did the product remove that people used to be able to do?
[plead your case to a person who could bend a rule]

Which power stayed the same, in a new form?
[the principal's signature became the college's online check]

Which direction of influence do you see more evidence for: people shaping the product, or the product shaping people?
[product → people: everyone had to change]

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS
[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

The Villain Story

Now imagine everything going wrong. Walk someone very unlike the ideal user through **your ideal flow from p.1.06**, one step at a time.

1 · YOUR VILLAIN PERSONA · orange notes · the story

My persona is [Meera, 19, applying on her phone], and their one hard constraint is [the registered phone is her father's]

2 · WALK THE FLOW

Step = a step number from your ideal flow on p.1.06. At each step, pick **one of the five failure cards** below: the one most likely to happen to this persona. Cut the cards out and lay one on each step, or just write its name.

STEP (FROM P.1.06)	FAILURE CARD	WHAT BROKE · WHAT THEY DID INSTEAD	HOW LIKELY	WHO PAYS, AND WHAT
[3]	[Object missing]	[no scanner, no PDF; pays a café]	[8/10]	[Meera: ₹30–50, half a day]
[4]	[Person unavailable]	[father in the field; OTP expires]	[7/10]	[a day; father's work]
			/10	
			/10	
			/10	

Star ★ the likeliest break.

3 · QUICK CHECK: WHO GETS BLAMED?

When step [3] fails, the error message makes it sound like the fault of ○ **the user** ○ **the product**. It should instead say ["Photos work too. We'll make the PDF for you."]

System failure

Something in your Systems row doesn't work.

Person unavailable

Someone from your People row isn't there.

Object missing

Something from your Objects row isn't at hand.

Information gap

They don't know it, and the product doesn't say.

No time

Everything is there, except the time it needs.

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY FORWARD · THE LIKELIEST BREAK

[step 3: no way to make a PDF on a phone (8/10)]

Ideal flow + what each step needs

Map the product's main feature the way the designers imagined it: everything works. Then write what each step quietly needs from the user.

The feature: [upload documents and submit] Its goal:

["application submitted, confirmation received"]

WRITE EACH STEP AS A SHORT VERB ON AN ORANGE NOTE. THEN FILL THE FOUR ROWS. · orange notes · the story

Steps as designed	1 [logs in with mobile]	2 [fills in details]	3 [uploads marksheet PDF]	4 [enters OTP]	5 [submits]	6 [gets confirmation]
People who must help?		[a parent, for income]	[café owner]	[father (his phone)]		
Objects what must they own?	[own phone number]	[Aadhaar]	[scanner, PDF]	[the registered phone]	[data pack]	[email]
Systems what else must work?	[SMS]	[Aadhaar match]	[upload]	[SMS on time]	[server]	[college checks]
Information what must they know?	[which number]	[exact spelling]	[under 200KB]	[OTP expires fast]	[midnight deadline]	[to chase the college]

Put a dot on every need the product leaves the user to sort out alone. Count them: ____ of ____

WHO WAS THIS DESIGNED FOR? · teal notes · what you think

This flow only works smoothly for someone who has

[their own laptop, a scanner, broadband and an uninterrupted hour]

ONE LINE TO CARRY FORWARD · THE STEP MOST LIKELY TO BREAK

[step 3, the upload: it needs a scanner and a PDF]

Zoom out from one user to everyone around the product: who built it, what it protects, and whose work keeps it running. Look things up rather than guessing.

It was built by [a government IT agency, through a vendor] . They seem to have been ☐ rushing ☐ saving money ☐ ticking boxes, because [errors read "file size exceeds limit"]

The most effort is demanded at [document checks] . That protects [the scheme from fraud]
 , not [students from failing] . Reaching a real person takes [4+] steps.

After using it, people are more ○ independent ○ dependent, because [they need a café and a father's phone] . It asks them to hand over [income, bank and ID details]

Would the product still work without them? ☐ Yes ☐ No

☐ Minor ☐ Major ☐ Critical

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

Make the stories compete

Copy your five carried lines. Then fill the sentences in order. Every blank should point to something you already wrote.

1 · YOUR CARRIED LINES · COPY, DON'T REREAD

Media [promises "one place, seamless"]

Gossip [nobody can tell you where your application is]

History [you can no longer plead your case to a person]

The Break [no way to make a PDF on a phone (8/10)]

Power [it only works because of unpaid helpers]

2 · THE SHARPEST CONTRADICTION

The product claims [to be one seamless place], but [the Villain Story] revealed

[it needs a scanner, a café and a father's phone]

3 · THREE POSSIBLE REDESIGNS · SPECIFIC SCREENS OR STEPS

A [photo-to-PDF inside the upload step] B [an error that says how to fix it] C

[OTP to a number she chooses]

The one that takes the most blame off the user is [A], because

[she no longer needs a scanner or a café]

4 · THE POWER TEST

If this were built, [students without scanners] would gain [a free way to submit].

[Cafés and agents] would resist it, because [they'd lose paid work]

5 · THE FINDING

This product assumes [a scanner and a PDF], but the user actually has

[a phone camera], which causes [a paid trip, a lost day and self-blame]

6 · THE DESIGN CLAIM

We should redesign [the upload step], because it would shift blame from

[the student] to [the portal's missing PDF path], and would specifically help

[students who only have a phone]